CHAPTER 38

CLARKE AND THE RED MIST

10–14 July 2013

ENGLAND vs AUSTRALIA, 1st Test, *Trent Bridge, Nottingham*

England 215 and 375; Australia 280 and 296

England won by 14 runs

Australia 1st innings**: J Anderson 24–2–85–5**; 2nd innings: **J Anderson 31.5–11–73–5**

It's the best team I've ever played in. We have achieved everything we set out to – beating Australia and India away from home, reaching number one in the world. The team still has every aspect covered too – real strength at the top, with a young Joe Root now opening the batting with Alastair Cook, the usual suspects in the middle order with Jonny Bairstow bolstering the pack, the best spinner in the world in Graeme Swann and a great unit of fast bowlers.

As the Red Arrows fly above before the Ashes start, there is no sense of time doing what it must to us. It's all just ceremony and habit now. Although the endorphins of winning have maybe rubbed off a touch, it has now become part of what we do. Between us, the tension and discipline is an accepted part of what being a successful cricketer is. We all have our internal battles, but we keep them internal, and when we come together, it is with a sense of commitment to a cause bigger than any individual career. After all, if you can't find that rush for an Ashes series, then what are you playing cricket for?

We have batted first and, on a true, dry wicket, have only managed to score 215. It's a worryingly low first innings score as we've not only won the toss with home advantage, but also know that Trent Bridge has a habit